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That India's telecom industry is among the fastest growing in the world is no secret. To add to it, as Indians, we enjoy the lowest telephone tariffs in the world. Attesting the significance of telecommunications in emerging India, the recently concluded 3G spectrum auction boosted the exchequer by approximately ₹67,719 crores (\$15.12 billion). What consumers don't realise readily is that this \$15 billion will be recovered indirectly in the form of access fee, and primarily tariffs. If your mobile operator paid ₹10,000 crore to be able to give you 3G services, there's no way it would be able to let you stream video and have video call conferences with the cheapest tariffs in the world.

3G SERVICES

Is it really here? Or do we wait and watch?

In early 2010, Sunil Mittal, Chairman, Bharti Airtel, had commented, "Take the example of Delhi itself, or Mumbai. The amount for spectrum that has been charged is close to ₹3,500 crore each... just to recover licence fees and input cost, it works out to be ₹700-900 per month," ₹700-900 per month doesn't really sound cheap by Indian standards. We're price conscious! However, while unveiling Airtel's new logo late in November 2010, all he had to say was that Airtel would ensure that 3G services are "affordable" (with no further elaboration).

It must be quite a nightmare for telcos that have paid large premiums to be

able to be eligible to operate 3G services in a few circles. A tricky scenario is that owing to complications and rising costs, no single operator has been able to bag a nationwide licence. Only three operators (Airtel, Vodafone and Reliance Communications) have bagged licences in the most number of circles – 13. In case you didn't know, the state of India is divided into nearly 24 telecom circles. A direct implication of this is that in case you are critically dependent on 3G for voice-data convergent communications, while on the move your operator needs to have significant tie-ups with fellow operators for roaming.

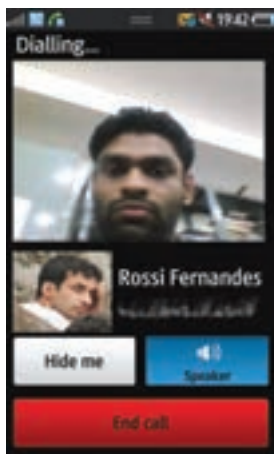
The only operators to effectively execute this synergy between the urban and rural divide in India are state-owned operators MTNL and BSNL. Where they do take a beating is customer service. As far service availability

is concerned, you should go on a road trip through the highways across the nation and experience BSNL's vast and deeply penetrated cellular network. Not very long ago, BSNL used to be 7th largest telecom operator in the world. If you are an existing 2G subscriber with any of the remaining private operators you wouldn't have access to this wide network in rural India. Also given that

no operator has a pan-India licence, your 3G licence will not be seamless when on roaming. Comparatively, GPRS and EDGE services are available in networks across the country.

First hand experience

State-owned operators MTNL and BSNL were the first to launch 3G services. In Mumbai, MTNL has been offering 3G services for over a year, yet the response has been mixed. To get a feel of user experience, we asked



Holding the phone in front of you doesn't feel very comfortable for long

HOW DOES SPECTRUM AFFECT US?

A spectrum is a range of electromagnetic frequencies that your mobile company needs to own to be able to beam the network to your handset. This is similar to the FM frequency owned by radio companies. Owning a frequency involves payments of hefty amounts and thereby involves humungous investments even before implementation of costly infrastructure required to begin operations. Given the critical and strategic commercial significance of allotting spectrum, increasingly governments around the globe prefer auctions rather than an apply-and-allocate approach and install time.

our readers about GSM 3G services.

We wanted to know for sure, so we got ourselves an MTNL SIM card. All said and done, we had our share of hiccups in the beginning. It began with the initial recharge. When we called up customer care to activate 3G, we got an announcement that said, "the number you have dialled does not exist." May be that was not the exact start we were looking forward to!

According to Tata DOCOMO's latest pricing, all calls are on a per-second pulse with a validity of one month.

Price ₹	Monthly minutes Local + STD	3G Data Units
500	750	250MB
750	1250	500 MB
1000	2000	1 GB
2000	5000	2 GB

When we sent the required message, we waited for a couple of hours to receive the necessary setting, but nothing happened.

Similarly, Digit community member Prasanna Vathanan adds, "I'm using BSNL 3G services on my HTC Hero. I'm able to view all mails easily and attachments and downloading is fast. It saves me time as I can view and respond to customer queries instantly, which is painful even on an EDGE network. I tried video calling, but it has a major disadvantage as you need to keep the phone in front of you and talk with everyone around able to hear you. There's no privacy in video calls. BSNL customer support and data plans are very bad. So